Example 1: Observing a Community in Singapore - Inmates and Ex-offenders

1 “My father was the abusive one. I only took drugs. I never harmed anyone, so why am I here but not him?” The barrage of difficult questions inmates at the Changi Prison Complex pose to volunteers does not end there. A volunteer counsellor explained the sense of injustice some inmates feel about their circumstances. Questions by inmates often get personal, especially when the volunteers are new. “Ma’am, what do you know? You live my life, then you know!” And volunteers who cannot manage these situations effectively are often met with rolling eyes and, at times, flying chairs. This discord between inmates and the public is evident even after inmates leave prison. In an interview, Benny Se Teo, founder of Eighteen Chefs, reveals that some of his chefs only listen to and respect other ex-offenders (MothershipSG, 2022).

2 On the other hand, many volunteers talk about the prevalence of a latent stigma against inmates. “When inmates are released, people who should be friendly towards them are not,” including family or potential employers. These people often label inmates as “untrustworthy offenders.” On the contrary, “those who shouldn’t be friendly towards [inmates] are,” including other offenders such as drug dealers. As a result, inmates who leave prison are often hurled back into it as they cannot navigate the world outside.

3 Seeing the perspectives of both inmates and non-inmates made me mindful of the tension between these groups. In this conflict, however, inmates appear to get the short end of the stick. Despite Singapore’s low recidivism rate internationally, more than 1 in 5 (Shanmugam, 2021) of our fellow Singaporeans return to prison within just two years of leaving. This fact made me wonder why some inmates struggled to reintegrate into society, and the stigmatisation I had observed struck me as one possibility. I, therefore, questioned: why do Singaporeans stigmatise offenders?